Session Report

Platform Team Offsite — Big Bets

Saturday, October 31, 2026

Session	Participants	Rounds
4417	8	3

Session

About this session

> Half-day offsite for the platform engineering group. We are deliberately setting today's constraints aside to find out what the team would build if staffing and budget were not the question.

What people were asked to do

Three rounds. Answer on your phone, read everyone's answers, then vote for your top three. Be specific — a named thing beats a category.

Attendance

Who was here

Priya Raman
Marcus Hale
Elena Sokolova
Tom Becker
Aisha Okafor
Jun Watanabe
Grace Liu
Dev Malhotra

Round 1 Big Bets

If we had unlimited people and resources, what should we build?

> Forget the roadmap and the headcount plan for a minute. If money and

> Forget the roadmap and the headcount plan for a minute. If money and people were not the constraint, what is the one thing this team should build — and why would it matter?

The taskHow could you adapt this lesson to your work, project, or team?

AI Analysis

Summary

The room split between **delight** and **drudgery**. The winning answer — a one-week tech-debt remover sold as a service — was the only one that named a customer who would pay, and it collected first-place votes from five of eight people.

What the room said

- The tech-debt remover read as a joke and was voted as a strategy: three people argued in comments that it is already what the platform team does, unbilled.
- The grass-seeding robot was the most *concrete* idea and the only one with a physical-world customer.
- The Rube Goldberg machine and the AI fax machine were voted as morale, not as bets.

Discussion Questions

1. If the tech-debt remover is what we already do, why is it invisible on the roadmap?
2. What would a one-week fixed-scope engagement have to exclude to be sellable?

Recommended Next Steps

1. Write a one-page offer for a fixed one-week debt sprint and test it with two internal teams.
2. Track debt work as its own line so its value is visible next quarter.

Player applications

🥇 1st Place

A for-hire one-week enterprise tech-debt remover

Elena Sokolova — 20 points — 5 first, 2 second, 1 third

🥈 2nd Place

A grass-seeding robot

Marcus Hale — 14 points — 2 first, 3 second, 2 third

🥉 3rd Place

An AI-enabled fax machine

Tom Becker — 10 points — 1 first, 2 second, 3 third

A Rube Goldberg machine

Priya Raman — 4 points — 0 first, 1 second, 2 third

Comments

On Response 1 — Elena Sokolova

A for-hire one-week enterprise tech-debt remover

Only half a joke. We do this every quarter for free and nobody budgets for it.

Aisha OkaforShown to the room

On Summary

The room split between delight and drudgery.

The fax machine got votes because it was funny. Do not read it as demand.

Jun Watanabe

Round 2 Proof

The Work We Would Show First

Round 2 Final The Work We Would Show First

> A serious buyer gets one thing from us before they decide anything, and it is not the roadmap - it is a piece of work that already exists. Pick the one you would put in front of them, and say what it proves that a claim could not.

The taskHow could you adapt this lesson to your work, project, or team?

AI Analysis

Summary

Almost every answer pointed at the **deploy pipeline**, not a product feature. The room believes its strongest proof is operational: things ship safely and often.

Recommended Next Steps

1. Turn the pipeline dashboard into a two-minute walkthrough a buyer can watch.

Player applications

🥇 1st Place

The zero-downtime migration runbook — it proves we finish hard things without an outage.

Priya Raman — 17 points — 4 first, 2 second, 1 third

🥈 2nd Place

Our deploy dashboard: 40 releases a week, nobody paged.

Grace Liu — 15 points — 3 first, 2 second, 2 third

🥉 3rd Place

The incident review archive, because it shows how we learn.

Dev Malhotra — 11 points — 1 first, 3 second, 2 third

Round 3 Positioning

The Sentence We Would Lead With

One sentence, in the words a customer would use rather than ours, saying what this team is for. Not a mission statement - the sentence you would actually say if you had ten seconds and one chance.

The taskHow could you adapt this lesson to your work, project, or team?

Player applications

🥇 1st Place

We make the boring parts of shipping disappear.

Marcus Hale — 16 points — 4 first, 1 second, 2 third

🥈 2nd Place

Your engineers ship features; we make sure they land.

Elena Sokolova — 13 points — 2 first, 3 second, 1 third

Standings

Final Scores

1. Session Champion

1 Priya Raman 34

2 Marcus Hale 29

3 Elena Sokolova 27

4 Tom Becker 22

5 Aisha Okafor 19

6 Jun Watanabe 15

7 Grace Liu 12

8 Dev Malhotra 8

End of report